

Kautilya (Chanakya) Study Guide

Statecraft, the seven limbs of the state, the circle of kings and the Arthashastra

Use this guide to: get the big picture fast, learn the key terms with everyday examples, see the Saptanga and Mandala models at a glance, and test yourself.

1. Kautilya at a glance

Fact	Detail
Names	Kautilya (the name in the text), Chanakya (popular name), Vishnugupta (name given in traditional accounts)
Traditional era	4th century BCE; by tradition the teacher and minister of Chandragupta Maurya, founder of the Maurya Empire (c. 321 BCE)
Main work	The Arthashastra: 15 books on kingship, administration, law, economy, diplomacy and war
Rediscovered	Manuscript found in the early 1900s by R. Shamasastry; Sanskrit edition 1909, English translation 1915
Best known for	Saptanga (seven limbs of the state), Mandala theory (circle of states), the four upayas, the six-fold foreign policy
Separate text	The Chanakya Niti is a later collection of maxims attributed to Chanakya; it is not part of the Arthashastra
Start reading with	Arthashastra Book 1 (training of the king), Book 6 (Saptanga and Mandala) and Book 7 (six-fold policy)

2. The big idea in 60 words

Kautilya treats politics as a practical science. A state is a body of seven interdependent parts, and the ruler's job is to keep them strong. Foreign policy is a calculation of power: neighbours tend to be rivals, their neighbours potential allies. Yet power serves welfare: a king's own happiness, he says, lies in the happiness of his subjects.

3. Who was he, and how sure are we?

Traditional accounts in Puranic, Buddhist, Jain and Sanskrit literary sources, including the play Mudrarakshasa, portray Chanakya as the brahmin strategist who helped Chandragupta overthrow the Nanda dynasty. Historians remain cautious. The Arthashastra names its author Kautilya, but scholars debate when and by whom the text reached its present form. Some place its core in the Mauryan period, while Patrick Olivelle argues it is a composite work assembled in roughly the 1st to 3rd centuries CE. Treat Chanakya as a powerful tradition, and the Arthashastra as the surer evidence.

4. What is in the Arthashastra?

The text is organised into 15 books (adhikaranas). Roughly half deal with running the state at home; the rest cover foreign policy and war.

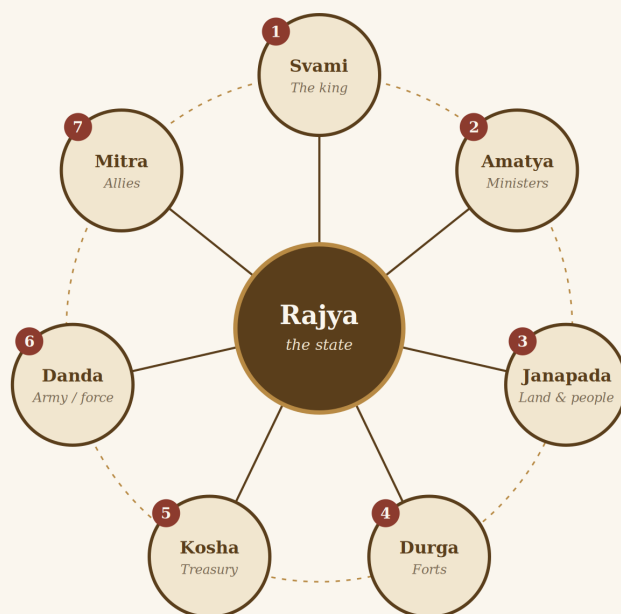
Book	Theme	Book	Theme
1	Training of the king, ministers, spies	9	Preparing for war
2	Duties of government superintendents (mines, trade, agriculture)	10	Fighting and battle
3	Civil law and courts	11	Dealing with oligarchic confederacies
4	Suppression of criminals and threats to order	12	The weaker king facing a stronger one
5	Conduct of officials and miscellaneous measures	13	Taking a fortress
6	Saptanga and Mandala (the state and the circle of states)	14	Secret and occult practices
7	The six-fold policy	15	How the treatise is organised
8	Vices and calamities that weaken a state		

5. Saptanga: the seven limbs of the state

Kautilya lists seven elements without which a state cannot function: Svami (king), Amatya (ministers), Janapada (land and people), Durga (forts), Kosha (treasury), Danda (army and enforcement) and Mitra (allies). He treats them as an organism: weakness in one limb weakens all, and a calamity in an earlier limb is graver than one in a later limb.

Saptanga: The Seven Limbs of the State

Kautilya's model of what makes a kingdom (Arthashastra, Book 6): a state is a body, and every limb must be sound



The seven limbs, in Kautilya's order

- 1 Svami (The king)**
Capable, trained, disciplined ruler; the head of the state.
- 2 Amatya (Ministers)**
Officials and counsellors who run administration and advise the king.
- 3 Janapada (Land & people)**
Productive territory and a loyal, working population.
- 4 Durga (Forts)**
Fortified strongholds (water, hill, desert, forest) for defence.
- 5 Kosha (Treasury)**
Stored wealth: the basis for paying army, officials and projects.
- 6 Danda (Army / force)**
Military and the power to enforce order and law.
- 7 Mitra (Allies)**
Friendly states that add strength and support in need.

Kautilya argues that a calamity in an earlier limb is worse than one in a later limb, so the king and ministers matter most.

Figure 1. The Saptanga model.

6. Mandala: the circle of states

The Mandala theory is Kautilya's map for a king who wants to expand (the Vijigishu). Placing the king at the centre, he reasons that the state next door is a likely enemy (Ari), the state beyond it a likely friend (Mitra), and so on in alternation, in front and behind. Two further kings sit outside the circle: the Madhyama (middle king) and the Udasina (indifferent king), both stronger and able to tip the balance.

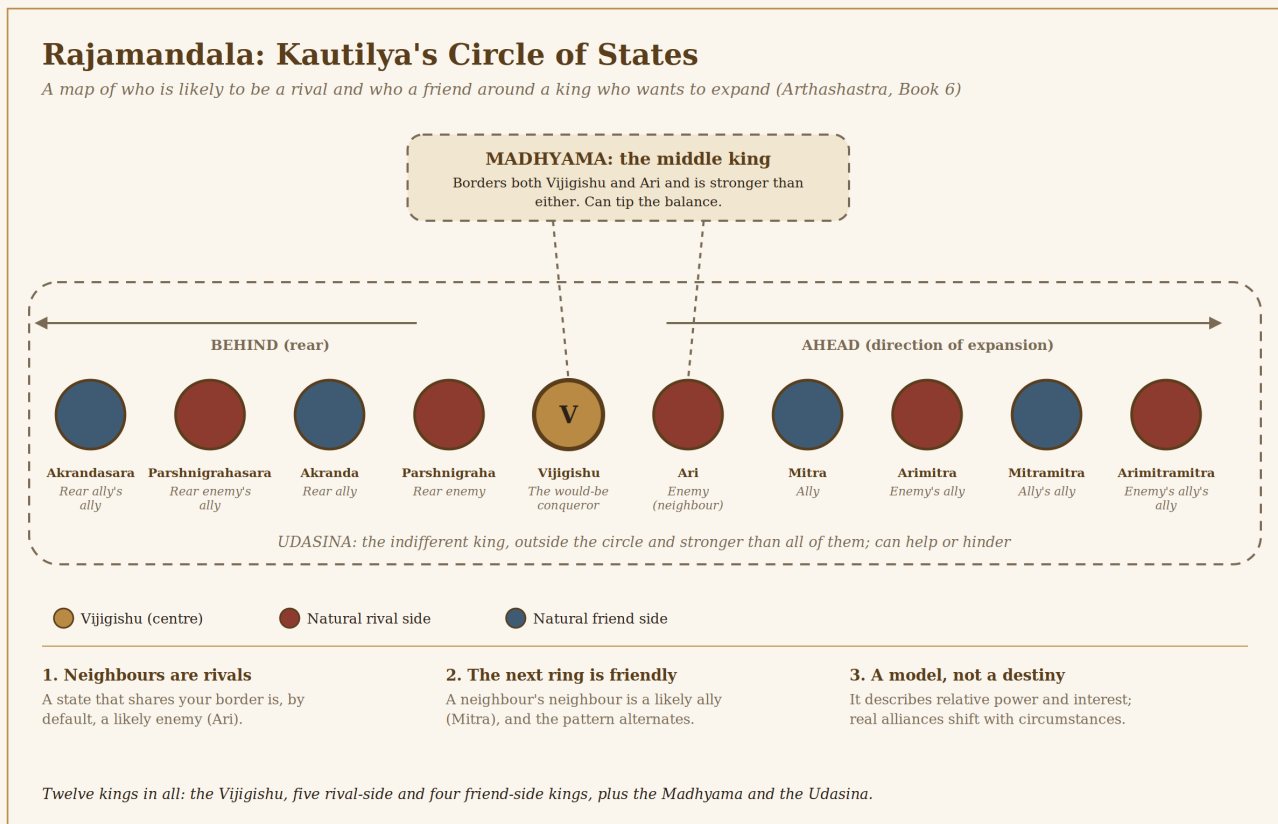


Figure 2. The Mandala model: twelve kings in total.

7. Key terms with everyday examples

Term	Plain-English meaning	Everyday example
Arthashastra	The science of material well-being and governance (artha)	A handbook on running a country or company: budgets, laws, security, diplomacy.
Rajya / Saptanga	The state and its seven limbs	Checking a country's leadership, bureaucracy, population, defences, finances, military and partners.
Vijigishu	The king who aims to expand or win	A firm that wants to grow its market share.
Mandala	The circle of surrounding states and their likely stance	Mapping which neighbours or rival companies might compete and which might cooperate.
Madhyama / Udasina	The middle king / the indifferent king	A big power next door that can mediate, or a distant power that stays out.
Gudhapurusha	Secret agents and informants	Intelligence services, market research on competitors.
Yogakshema	Security and welfare of subjects	Public health, disaster relief, food storage.

8. The four upayas and the six-fold policy

Kautilya's toolkit for dealing with others has two parts. The four upayas are Sama (conciliation), Dana (gifts), Bheda (division) and Danda (force). The six-fold policy (Sadgunya) says which stance to adopt depending on relative strength.

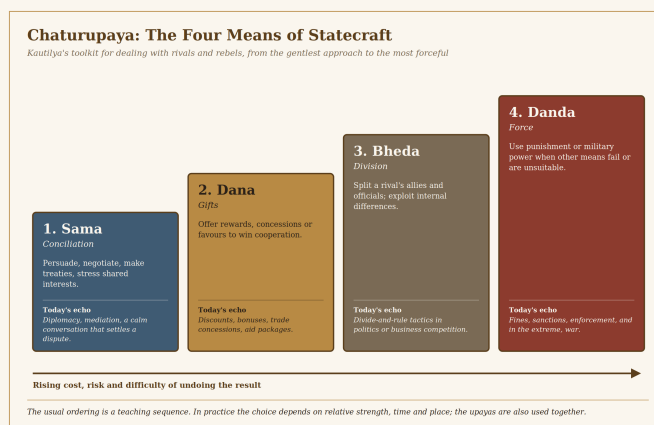


Figure 3. The four upayas.

Gunya	Meaning	When it fits
Sandhi	Peace or treaty	When you are weaker, or war would cost more than it gains
Vigraha	War or hostility	When you are stronger and the gain is clear
Asana	Staying quiet, waiting	When neither side can gain an advantage
Yana	Marching or preparing to attack	When your strength and timing favour action
Samshraya	Seeking shelter with a stronger ally	When you cannot defend alone
Dvaidhibhava	Dual policy: peace with one, war with another	When you must handle two rivals at once

9. Common misconceptions

- "**The Machiavelli of India.**" The label is popular, but the Arthashastra is also about taxation, law, trade and public welfare, and it ties the ruler's success to the well-being of subjects.
- "**Chanakya wrote the Chanakya Niti.**" The Niti is a later set of maxims attributed to him, separate from the Arthashastra.
- "**Mandala predicts who will be an enemy.**" It is a model of likelihood and interest; actual alliances shift.

10. Main criticisms

Critics note that the text's date and authorship are uncertain, that it may describe an ideal more than the actual Mauryan state, that its ethics of statecraft allow deception and coercion, and that its social rules reflect the hierarchies of its time. Defenders reply that it pairs power with duty and welfare.

11. Test yourself

- List the seven limbs of the state and explain why a fort or treasury alone is not enough.
- Why does Kautilya treat a neighbouring state as a likely enemy, and a neighbour's neighbour as a likely ally?
- Who are the Madhyama and the Udasina, and why do they matter?
- Pick a modern dispute and say which upaya or gunya fits it best.

Answer hints: 1. King, ministers, land and people, forts, treasury, army, allies; they work together as one body. 2. Shared borders create competition, so the next ring is a natural friend of your rival's enemy. 3. Outside powers stronger than the main rivals; they can tilt outcomes. 4. Justify with relative strength and cost.

Sources and further reading: Kangle, R. P. *The Kautilya Arthashastra* (Univ. of Bombay, 1960-65). Olivelle, P. *King, Governance, and Law in Ancient India: Kautilya's Arthashastra* (Oxford UP, 2013). Rangarajan, L. N. *The Arthashastra* (Penguin, 1992). Shamasastri, R. *Kautilya's Arthashastra* (1915). Trautmann, T. *Kautilya and the Arthashastra* (Brill, 1971).

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